

A vibrant, painterly illustration of outer space. In the upper right, a white rocket ship with orange and black stripes on its boosters is shown launching, with a large, bright yellow flame trail. A large, pale yellow planet with subtle surface details is positioned in the center. To the left, three comets with long, glowing tails (white, white, and green) streak across the sky. The background is a deep blue space filled with numerous small white stars. Two spiral galaxies are visible in the lower half of the image. White dashed lines curve across the lower portion of the frame. In the bottom left corner, a small patch of green ground with two white clouds is visible.

Earth and space scientists study changes that happen over billions of years, far beyond the scale and scope of a human life. To do this, they must piece together clues from ancient rocks and distant stars. The reward is understanding the strange structures of the universe, including our very own special planet.